

# Managing modifiers

A MODIFIER IS A WORD, PHRASE, OR CLAUSE THAT DESCRIBES ANOTHER WORD, PHRASE, OR CLAUSE.

Used correctly, modifiers make sentences more descriptive and therefore more interesting. If a modifier is put in the wrong place in a sentence, however, it can alter the whole meaning of that sentence.

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## Misplaced adverbs

Common one-word modifiers include the adverbs *only*, *almost*, *just*, and *nearly*. These adverb modifiers are usually placed right before the word they modify. If a modifier is in the wrong place, the intended meaning may not be clear, and the modifier may end up modifying the wrong person or thing.

This means that I spoke to Maria very recently, and asked her to lunch.

I **just** asked Maria to lunch.

This means that I asked Maria to lunch, and no one else.

I asked **just** Maria to lunch.

This means that I was tempted to eat a whole pie, but I didn't eat any of it.

I **almost** ate a whole pie.

This means that I ate the pie, and ate most of it.

I ate **almost** a whole pie.

The comedian Groucho Marx **humorously** used a **misplaced modifier**: “One morning I shot an elephant **in my pajamas**. How he got into my pajamas I’ll never know.”

## Misplaced adjectives

Like adverb modifiers, adjective modifiers should be placed as close as possible to the person or thing they describe. Misplaced adjectives tend to occur when a noun is described by several words.

This adjective is describing a silver woman, not a silver bracelet.

Jim found a **silver** woman's bracelet.



Jim found a woman's **silver** bracelet.

The adjective is now describing a silver bracelet that belongs to a woman.



## GLOSSARY

**Dangling participle** When a modifying phrase or clause that starts with a participle is put in the wrong place in a sentence, it is described as “dangling,” because it has no subject to hold on to.

**Main clause** A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

**Misplaced modifier** A modifier that has been placed so far from the person or thing it is intended to modify that it appears to modify a different person or thing.

**Participle** The form of a verb that ends in -ing (present participle) or -ed or -en (past participle).

**Subject** The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

**Subordinate clause** A group of words that contains a subject and a verb but depends on a main clause for its meaning.